LECTURE 12: WRITING SKILLS

Hello and welcome to lecture 10 on writing skills. I hope you are enjoying your lectures on communication Skills. So far we have been discussing various communication skills including listening, speaking and reading. Now we are going to look at the writing skills. We shall look at the general importance of writing and this will be followed by several lectures on different sorts of writing which you might come across not only in your day- to- day lives, but also in your professional lives.

Expected learning outcomes

By the end of the lesson, you should be able to:

i. Identify and explain a topic sentence in a paragraph.
ii. Explain what a paragraph is
iii. Explain the qualities of a good paragraph.
iv. Describe the different types of paragraphs and their methods of development.
v. Identify and explain the different parts of an essay.

What is writing?

Writing is a form of communication that allows students to put their feelings and ideas on paper, to organize their knowledge and beliefs into convincing arguments, and to convey meaning through well-constructed text. In its most advanced form, written expression can be as vivid as a work of art. As children learn the steps of writing, and as they build new skills upon old, writing evolves from the first simple sentences to elaborate stories and essays. Spelling, vocabulary, grammar, and organization come together and grow together to help the student demonstrate more advanced writing skills each year.

THE BUILDING BLOCKS OF WRITTEN LANGUAGE

There are different levels of structure within written language. These are:

Text

Paragraph

Sentence

Clause

phrase

word

WRITING EFFECTIVE SENTENCE

Definition and elements of a sentence

What is a sentence?

When we talk or write in English, we use sentences to express ourselves.

A sentence is a group of words that communicates a complete thought (Example: John goes to school). A group of words, which does not make complete sense, is known as a phrase (Example: John goes). A sentence always begins with a capital letter, and it always ends with a question mark, full stop or exclamation mark.

To express a complete thought, a sentence must have two parts: a subject and a predicate. This means there are two major elements (subject and predicate) in the structure of a sentence.

Example: Ato Legesse is our English teacher.

In the example above, *Ato Legesse* is a subject of the sentence while *is our English teacher* is a predicate.

When we write a sentence, we should include these parts: subject and predicate.

Subject and Predicate

A **subject** is part of a sentence which tells the reader who or what a sentence is about. In other words, a subject names the person, place, thing or idea the sentence is about.

A **predicate** completes the thought (sentence) by telling something about the subject.

Finding a Subject

The subject of the sentence is usually found at the beginning of the sentence, preceding the verb. However, this is not always the case. A sentence may appear in the middle or even at the end of the sentence. Therefore, wherever it is, we can easily find the subject based on its definition.

Sentences are important because if you do not clearly write sentences then, the meaning of the same cannot be understood clearly.

Now underline the subject of the following sentences.

1. Have you finished your classwork?
2. There are forty students in the class.
3. Here is no electricity.
4. Over the roof of the house is a flower.
5. Make a dessert for the party.
6. Open the door.
7. Abel, please give me 100 birr.

As you may have noticed, the position of subject is not at the beginning in the above sentences. You can get the subjects by asking the questions stated above or changing the inverted sentences into normal order. In the latter case, you will find the subject at the beginning of the sentence.

Note that both subject and predicate may be simple or compound. We say a sentence has simple subject when it has only one subject; if it has two or more subjects, we say that it has compound subject. The same is true for predicate.

The students are coming to class. *This sentence is with simple subject.*

The students and the teachers are coming to class. *This sentence is with compound subject.*

Abebe is eating lunch. *This sentence has single subject and single predicate.*

Abebe is eating lunch and drinking milk. *This sentence has single subject and Compound predicate.*

Abebe and his wife are eating lunch and drinking milk. *This sentence has compound subject*

TYPES OF SENTENCE

A sentence can be classified based on two categories: functional and structural. In both cases there are four kinds of sentence.

A) Functional Classification of Sentences

According to the function of a sentence, there are four types of sentence. These are:

a) Declarative Sentence
b) Imperative Sentence
c) Interrogative Sentence
d) Exclamatory Sentence

B) Structural Classification of Sentences

Sentences can also be classified into four based on grammatical structure they have. These are :

a) Simple Sentence
b) Compound Sentence
c) Complex Sentence
d) Compound-complex Sentence

Techniques of combining sentences

i. Coordination
ii. Subordination
iii. Correlation
iv. Using Relative Pronouns

PARAGRAPH WRITING

Definition and Structure of Paragraph

♦ ***Definition:*** *Paragraph is a group of logically related sentences that present s or develops ONE main idea.*

Whatever the length or width of a paragraph may be, there is ONLY ONE main idea in the paragraph.

♦ ***Paragraph Structure***
- ♣ *Topic sentence*
- ♣ *Supporting sentences (details)*
- ♣ *Concluding sentence*

1. Topic Sentence

- *T.S the sentence that states the main idea of a paragraph.*
- *T. S is the most important sentence in a paragraph (back bone of paragraph).*
- *It has two parts: topic and controlling idea*

e.g. *Hawassa <u>is one of the most beautiful cities of the country.</u>*

↓ ↓

topic *controlling idea*

Exercise

Identify the topic and controlling idea of the following topic sentences.

a) There are three main kinds of holidays.
b) India celebrates Christian Hindu and Islamic holidays.
c) Different countries have unique ideas about Santa Clause.

2. Supporting sentences (details)

Supporting sentences are sentences that support or explain the topic sentence(the main idea)

There might be major and minor supporting sentences in a paragraph.
Supporting sentences could be examples, facts, reasons, sensory details, events and experts' opinions that the writer uses to support the main idea.

3. Concluding sentence

. C.S displays the end of the paragraph
. It concludes the main idea of the paragraph raised in the topic sentence.
. Generally needed in a stand-alone paragraph.
. Usually begins with a transition such as

In general,	*In summary,*
In short,	*To sum up,*
In conclusion,	*All in all,*

Locations of Topic Sentence

a) At the beginning of a paragraph (the most common location)
b) In the middle of the paragraph
c) At the end of a paragraph

Beginner writers are advised to begin writing a paragraph with the topic sentence because it guides (controls) them not to include irrelevant ideas.

Qualities of a Good Paragraph

A good paragraph possesses the following qualities:

- **Unity:** all sentences in a paragraph should say about only one main idea (raised in the T.S)
- **Coherence:** all supporting sentences should be logically arranged so that the reader can understand them easily.

There are different techniques to establish coherence in a paragraph:

    * Repeating key (content) words
    * Using synonyms
    * Using pronouns
    * Using transitions (cohesive words)
- **Completeness**: the supporting sentences should adequately state the main idea (controlling idea of the T.S)
- **Sentence variety:** using variety of sentences in a paragraph

  Ways of establishing sentence variety:
  - Varying sentence beginning (pronouns, participial phrases, infinitive phrases, main clause, subordinate clauses, etc.)
  - Varying sentence type (simple, compound, complex, compound complex)
  - Varying sentence length (short, long)

A Model Paragraph

An Expensive Holiday

A valentine's day is a very expensive holiday. Typically, people who are in love with each other exchange gifts. The gifts often cost a lot of money, sometimes as much as $100. If you don't spend that much, your sweetheart might think you don't care. For example, one of the most popular gifts is chocolate. One box of nice chocolates may cost $20 or more, which adds up to million dollars or more spent in the United States on chocolate for a single day! Flowers are also a common gift, and they cost more than a chocolate, so sales of flowers may amount to $5 million in one day! In addition, it is often expected that you and your sweetheart will go out to dinner in that evening. A romantic dinner at a nice restaurant may cost $100 or more per person. In conclusion, if you plan to celebrate a Valentine's Day, make sure that you have a lot of money.

Summary

♥ *A paragraph presents only one main idea.*

♥ *The paragraph consists of 3 components: topic sentence, supporting sentences (details) and concluding sentence.*

♥ *A good paragraph has 4 main qualities: unity, coherence, adequacy (completeness) and variety.*

STEPS OF PARAGRAPH WRITING

There are four main stages in which we have categorized paragraph writing so as to make it a lot easier for you to learn the art. The four stages of writing are:

- Prewriting
- Writing the First Draft
- Editing and Proofreading
- Writing the Final Copy (Publishing)

1. Prewriting

The prewriting stage is when you think carefully and organize your ideas for your paragraph before you begin writing.
It consists of 5 stages:

1. Think carefully about what you are going to write (Select a topic and specify it.)
2. Collect facts related to your paragraph topic.
3. Outline your main ideas.
4. Find the main idea of your paragraph.
5. Organize your facts and ideas in a way that develops your main idea.

1. Think carefully about what you are going to write.

Ask yourself the following questions:

- ❑ What question am I going to answer in this paragraph?
- ❑ How can I best answer this question? What is the most important part of my answer?
- ❑ How can I make an introductory sentence from the most important part of my answer?
- ❑ What facts or ideas can I use to support my introductory sentence?
- ❑ How can I make this paragraph interesting?
- ❑ Do I need more facts on this topic? Where can I find more facts on this topic?

2. Open your notebook and start writing outline of the paragraph.

- ❑ Jot down your answers to the above questions. You do not need to spend a lot of time doing this.
- ❑ Just write enough to help you remember why and how you are going to write your paragraph.

3. Collect facts related to your paragraph topic.

Look for and write down facts that will help you to answer your question.

4. Write down your own ideas.

Ask yourself:

- ❑ What else do I want to say about this topic?
- ❑ Why should people be interested in this topic?
- ❑ Why is this topic important?

5. Find the main idea of your paragraph.

- ❑ Choose the most important point you are going to present.
- ❑ If you cannot decide which point is the most important, just choose one point and stick to it throughout your paragraph.

6. Organize your facts and ideas in a way that develops your main idea.

Once you have chosen the most important point of your paragraph, you must:

- ❑ Find the best way to tell your reader about it.
- ❑ Look at the facts you have written.
- ❑ Look at your own ideas on the topic.
- ❑ Decide which facts and ideas will best support the main idea of your paragraph.
- ❑ Once you have chosen the facts and ideas you plan to use, ask yourself which order to put them in the paragraph.
- ❑ Write down your own note so that you can use to guide yourself as you write your paragraph.

2. Draft Writing

The writing stage is when you turn your ideas into sentences.
Five Writing Steps:

1. Open your notebook or word processor.
2. Write the topic sentence, supporting sentences and closing sentence.
3. Write clear and simple sentences to express your meaning.
4. Focus on the main idea of your paragraph.
5. Use dictionary to help you find additional words to express your ideas.

3. Editing and Proofreading

The editing stage is when you check your paragraph for mistakes and correct them. You check for grammar and spelling, style and organization and proofread after making all necessary corrections.

- ❖ *Grammar and Spelling*
    1. Check your spelling.
    2. Check your grammar.
    3. Read your Paragraph (assignment) again.
    4. Make sure each sentence has a subject and predicate.
    5. See if your subjects and verbs agree with each other.
    6. Check the verb tenses of each sentence.
    7. Make sure that each sentence makes sense.

- ❖ *Style and Organization*

1. Make sure your paragraph has a topic sentence.
2. Make sure your supporting sentences focus on the main idea.
3. Make sure you have a closing sentence.
4. Check that all your sentences focus on the main idea.
5. See if your paragraph is interesting.

- *Read your entire paragraph again as if it were written by someone else.*

4. Writing the Final Copy (Publishing)

The publishing stage is when you produce a final copy of your paragraph (assignment) to hand in. The six most vital publishing steps are:

1. Make a paper copy of your paragraph.
2. Show your work to your peers, parents or tutor.
3. Ask them for hints on how to improve your writing.
4. Write again incorporating all constructive suggestions.
5. Read your work as if you are a reader and correct if there are any problems.
6. Finally write the final copy or publish without a mess.

METHODS OF PARAGRAPH (ESSAY) DEVELOPMENT

A carpenter uses a hammer to build a house. A painter uses a brush to paint a landscape. Writers use various rhetorical strategies to develop arguments. In order to develop paragraphs, you need to learn the following paragraph development strategies (methods): narration, process, description, illustration, compare-and-contrast, cause-and-effect, definition, classification.

1. *Narration*

Narration describes the passing of time. When we arrange events according to time, we put them in chronological or time order, for example:

a. Yesterday, Fatima got up at seven o'clock and took a shower. After that she had breakfast, then rode the bus to work. When she got to work, she checked her email, then discussed the new business plan with her colleagues.
b. Every Monday after class, Miguel goes to the gym and practices karate for three hours. When he has finished, he goes shopping, then takes the bus home.

2. *Process*

Process means putting events in sequential or step-by-step order. In the following examples, notice how each step-by-step process also describes the passing of time.

a. When making tea, first boil water. Next, put a tea bag into a cup. When the water is boiling, pour the water into the cup. Finally, add milk and sugar as you prefer.
b. *Titanic* hit an iceberg, broke in two, then sank.

3. *Description*

Description creates pictures of people, places and things using adjectives and adverbs. Description appeals to the senses: smell, sight, taste, hearing and touch.

a. Alexander, the keyboard player in the band, is wearing a black leather jacket, faded jeans and red cowboy boots.

b. The old man lived alone in an old house high on a rugged cliff overlooking a stormy sea.

4. *Illustration*

Illustration means example or supporting illustration, for example:

a. There are many places to go for a honeymoon. For example, many newlyweds go to Hawaii.

b. When you visit Manhattan, I suggest you visit Times Square and Central Park.

5. *Compare-and-Contrast*

Compare-and-contrast describes the differences and similarities between two or more objects, people or ideas. Compare-and-contrast also describes differences in opinion, for example:

a. Raquel tried the apple pie and decided the cherry pie was sweeter.

b. Ivan believes that all high school students should wear school uniforms; however, Paula believes that students should have the right to choose what they want to wear.

6. *Cause-and-Effect*

Cause-and-effect means action and result. We use cause-and-effect to describe an action and the results, or consequences, of that action, for example:

a. Mohammed studied hard and got a high TOEFL score.

b. Global warming is melting the ice at the North Pole.

7. *Definition*

A definition is a detailed description of a person, place, object or idea. The purpose of a definition is to give meaning, for example:

a. The dodo was a flightless bird native to New Zealand.

b. TOEFL is an English language proficiency test developed and implemented by Educational Testing Services (ETS) located in Princeton, New Jersey.

8. *Classification*

To classify means to put people, things or ideas into sub groups under a main topic, for example:

a. There are three kinds of wine: red, white and rosé.

b. TOEFL, TOEIC and IELTS are English language proficiency tests.

9. Analogy

Analogy provides a method of comparing a subject to something else familiar to the audience. It gives examples of similar circumstances/conditions/contexts/concepts, for example: a. For an employee, Eliminating from work is similar to losing a limb.

b. Learning in the university is burning.

c. Life is like a ladder – while one goes up, the other goes down.

Transitional Words and Varieties of Relationships

Type of Relationship	*Transitional Words*
Chronological order (order in time)	before, after, soon, since, once, then, when, first, next, while, finally, suddenly, now, later, until, at the same time ,as soon as, whenever
Spatial order (order in space)	above, below, beside, here, there, across, opposite, next to, near, where
Order of importance	first, second, last, finally, more important, least, better, best, most of all
Similarities and differences	Like, likewise, same as, similarly, in the same way, in contrast, unlike, on the other hand, nevertheless, different from,
Cause and effect	Because, therefore, so, as a result, consequently, thus, since, for that reason
Addition	And, also, again, furthermore, in addition, moreover, equally
Example (illustration)	For example, for instance, such as, that is, along with, like, as, in other words

TYPES OF PARAGRAPH

There are many types of paragraphs. These are: Expository, descriptive, Narrative, Definition, argumentative

We shall now introduce to each of them and look at examples as well as methods of developing each.

1. Expository Paragraph

- An expository paragraph is a paragraph that explains or informs ideas, object or phenomenon.

  It explains, analyzes, defines, compare and illustrate. It answers questions like What? Why? How? What was the cause? The effect? Like what? Unlike what? It is also the kind of paragraph we write in reports or term papers or tests.

- It can list facts, show cause and effect, compare and contrast, explain instructions/processes or gives sets of directions.
- Examples of expository paragraph

  - Essay tests - Information convey - Report

Look at a model expository paragraph below.

An Expensive Holiday

A valentine's day is a very expensive holiday. Typically, people who are in love with each other exchange gifts. The gifts often cost a lot of money, sometimes as much as $100. If you don't spend that much, your sweetheart might think you don't care. For example one of the most popular gifts is chocolate. One box of nice chocolates may cost $20 or more, which adds up to million dollars or more spent in the United States on chocolate for a single day! Flowers are also a common gift, and they cost more than a chocolate, so sales of flowers may amount to $5 million in one day! In addition, it is often expected that you and your sweetheart will go out to dinner in that evening. A romantic dinner at a nice restaurant may cost $100 or more per person. In conclusion, if you plan to celebrate a Valentine's Day, make sure that you have a lot of money.

Methods of expository Paragraph Development

- There are many different ways to develop an expository paragraph. The appropriate way of development, in fact, is determined by the topic sentence and the question it raises.
- The topic sentence and the question it raises usually hold the key to the best method of explaining. For example,

1. Topic sentence: Rehearsing an orchestra is a painstaking process.

   Question raised: What is this process?

   Way to explain: Steps in a process

2. Topic sentence: Every symphony orchestra has four main groups of musical instruments.

   Question raised: What are the four groups?

   Way to explain: Analysis

3. Topic sentence: There are many different types of plants.

   Question raised: What makes one type different from the other?

   Way to explain: Classification

Based on these, we can use the following methods of paragraph development.

- Facts and examples(exemplification or illustration)
- Steps in a process
- Set of directions
- Definition

- Comparison and contrast
- Cause and effect
- Classification
- Analysis
- Analogy

Methods of Paragraph Organization

Most expository paragraphs use *order of importance* and *developmental order*.

- ***Order of importance*** *- arranging details in the order of least to most (most to least) important, interesting, or sizable.*
- ***Developmental order*** *(Order of Development) - arranging ideas of equal importance in a way that shows the development of the writer's thoughts.*

However, the best method to organize an expository paragraph depends on its method of development. For example,

- ***Chronological order*** *– if the supporting details are events, steps in a process, or set of directions*
- ***Spatial order*** *– if supporting details analyze a subject by showing what it is made of.*

2. **Descriptive Paragraph**

A descriptive paragraph paints *a vivid picture* of a person, an object or a scen

Types of Description

a. ***Objective*** – reports accurate appearance of the thing being described /without writers impression/

b. ***Impressionistic*** - the writer adds his/her own feeling, opinion and impression.

The impression can be either +ve or -ve

+ve overall impression

The sun glowed outside, inviting everyone indoors to leave what they were doing.

-ve overall impression

The sun feel in burning streaks though the trees, disturbing all who had no choice but to be in the streets.

The topic sentence of a descriptive paragraph will depend on the writer's overall impression of the subject.

C. Scientific - characterized by its objectivity, clarity and precision.

- As science deals with concrete facts and general principles, in scientific description words are used to express different levels of abstraction.

- Technical words are also used.

Methods of descriptive paragraph Development

- Sensory details and figurative language
- Spatial order
- Compare and contrast (if you are describing two cars)

Examples of Descriptive Paragraph

☺ Describing a person

Thomas's mother was a tall blonde woman with whale-gray eyes that matched her son's. Her smile was as dazzling as the diamonds that sparkled on her ears and hands whenever she moved. Her pearl-gray cashmere sweater and silk skirt matched her elegant shoes perfectly.

☺ Describing a scene (place)

Outside, the immense blue Martian sky was hot and still as a warm deep sea water. The Martian desert lay broiling like a prehistoric mud pot, waves of heat rising and shimmering. There was a small rocket ship reclining upon a hilltop nearby. Large footprints came from the rocket to the door of this stone house. . . . After fifteen minutes the Earth men began walking in and out the kitchen door, with nothing to do.

3. Narrative Paragraph

A narrative paragraph tells a real or imaginary story with clear beginning, middle and ending.

-We use narrative writing when our purpose is to tell what happened.

-letters -fables

-news stories - fairy tales

-short stories -histories

-novels - biographies

Method of narrative Paragraph Development

-The topic sentence in narrative paragraph

- Sets the scene

- Captures the reader's attention or
- Sets the story in motion.

- The supporting sentences then tell the story.

- are events that make up the story.

- The concluding sentence gives the outcome of the story.

Paragraph Organization Method

Use of ***chronological order*** and transitions to organize your narrative.

-The events that make up the story are usually presented in the order in which they happened. (This is called chronological order.)

- Writers use transition words and phrases to help readers understand the time order of events.

Point of view

The person whose "voice" is telling the story in the narrative writing is called the narrator.

It can be the first (third person) narrator.

- Use first person point of view if you are a character in the story.
- Use third person point of view if you are reporting what happened to others.

Tense

Usually past simple tense is used

An Example of Narrative Paragraph

Golden Touch

King Midas was a kind but foolish man who lived in Greece long ago. One day, in exchange for a kindness, he was granted a wish. Without thinking of the consequences of his wish, King Midas asked that everything he touched would turn to gold. The "golden touch," as it was called, made him very rich. Unfortunately, however, even his food and drink turned to gold. He could not eat or drink. But the worst thing was what happened when his daughter ran to hug him. She, too, turned to gold! Finally, King Midas begged to have his golden touch removed. When he was granted this second wish, his daughter was restored to life.

4. Argumentative Paragraph

An argumentative paragraph states an opinion and uses facts, examples, reasons, and the opinions of expects to convince readers.

- Purpose of argumentative writing is to share your view to readers (to convert the reader to writer's way of thinking).

- The challenge of persuasive writing is to win your readers over to your way of thinking.

Argumentative Paragraph Development Method

The topic sentence in an argumentative paragraph asserts opinion, not fact. The supporting sentences back up the opinion. The most reliable kinds of support are:

-facts

-example

-reasons

-experts 'opinion on the subject

Paragraph Organization Method

Organization is especially important in argumentative writing.

Much persuasive writing is organized in order of importance.

e. g. paragraph: *College and Jobs* (Heath … p.429)

College and Jobs

People facing a decision about college should understand the relation between college and jobs. First of all, many good jobs do not require a college education. The Department of Labor estimated that 80% of the new jobs in 1983 required vocational or technical traing, but not a college degree. Second, even in some jobs that usually require a college degree, people with drive and determination can often succeed without a college degree. President Harry Truman, for example, never attended college. Most important, most recent college graduates who hoped to find work related to their field of study have been unable to do so. In the 1970s, 75% of the social science majors and 66% of the humanities majors wound up as either sales people or clerical workers. Although there are many good reasons for going to college-including studying a favorite field, making new friends, and broadening your outlook on life-college is no guarantee of a satisfying job in the future.

ESSAY WRITING

So far we have looking at the basic building blocks in writing namely: the sentence and the paragraph. Now we want to focus on another basic component of writing : the essa.

What is an essay?

- is a relatively short composition.

- a group of paragraphs that presents one main idea.

Sections (structure) of an essay

A well-written essay has three major parts:

- introductory paragraph
- body of paragraphs and
- concluding paragraph.

Each of them plays its roles in the development of the essay.

1. Introductory paragraph

The purpose of the introduction is to let the reader know

a) The topic

b) The aspect of the topic being dealt with

c) The stand (attitude) taken by the writer to the topic.

In other words, the introduction actually contains the conclusion!

- A good introduction requires several elements:
  - Opening sentences introducing to the topic of the essay
  - Background information on it (gradually leading to the analyzed aspect of the theme).
  - Literature techniques to grab the reader's attention.
  - A strong **thesis statement** defining and stating the point the author is making in the essay, the paper's main argument.
  - Introduction of any essay should be no longer than 1/10 of its length.
  - The content of an introduction has a deductive nature, as it leads the reader from the general views or positions on the analyzed topics to the specific narrow theme of the essay.

Writing the Thesis Sentence

- The thesis sentence states each of the major topics in a multi-paragraph paper.
- It has two characteristics:
  - It states or suggests the topics of each of the body paragraphs. Thus, a five-paragraph theme will have a thesis sentence suggesting three ideas.
  - It states or implies the order in which the ideas will appear.
- In other words, the subtopic appearing first in the thesis sentence appears in the first body paragraph.

How to Write an Introduction Paragraph

The introduction is the first part of your writing that the reader will see, and must capture their attention so they continue reading your work.

The introduction of any piece of writing is integral because it summarizes what the writer will say in his writing, and because it captures the attention of the reader and encourages the reader to continue reading.

The Elements of the Introduction

The introduction should include a few different elements, all of which help to capture the attention of the reader:

- A hook sentence
- A basic explanation of the topic
- A "menu" of the points or arguments
- A thesis statement

A good tip to remember is that the introduction should be shaped like an upside down pyramid. This means that the introduction will start off with general information about the topic, and then get more and more specific, until the thesis is stated. This format is generally preferred for academic writings.

The Hook

The hook sentence is the first sentence in the introduction, and is what captures the reader's attention right away. It must be interesting, but should also be general. An example of a good hook in an introduction paragraph about *Romeo and Juliet* would be:

"The theme of disobedience towards parents by teenagers is universal, and is apparent even in the artistic works of the 1400s."

This sentence is general enough to make the reader wonder what the piece is about, but relates to the point of the writing.

The Explanation

The basic explanation should summarize what the writing is about in a sentence or two. It should be more specific than the hook, but less specific than the "menu" which will follow it. Basically, the explanation will be specific to the topic of the writing but not what is being proven. Continuing the same subject as the explanation above, an example of a good explanation would be as follows:

"This theme is clearly shown in Shakespeare's work, Romeo and Juliet, as an ancient feud between their families forbids them from loving each other. They go against their parent's wishes, and pay with their lives."

These few sentences expand on the hook, and give the reader a much better idea about what the writing is about.

The Menu

The menu of the introduction should explain what points (or arguments) that are going to be made in the rest of the writing. It should basically list, in sentence form, the points and a short explanation of the proofs or further information for each point. For example:

"Both Romeo and Juliet are irresponsible, because they did not listen to the advice given to them by their respective advisors, Friar Lawrence and the Nurse. Also, both characters continued to see each other, and married each other behind their parent's backs. Their actions led to the deaths of Mercutio, a friend of Romeo's, and Tybalt, Juliet's cousin."

The menu explains specifically the points that will be made in the writing, and summarizes what will be explained further on in the writing. It also begins to set up the general position of the writing, which the thesis will complete.

The Thesis Statement

The thesis statement is the last sentence of the introduction paragraph, and states definitively the position that the piece takes on the topic. It is the most specific part of the introduction. For example:

"For these reasons, the characters of Romeo and Juliet in Shakespeare's Romeo and Juliet are irresponsible."

Short and sweet, that's what a thesis statement should generally look like.

2. Body paragraphs

- The body will typically consist of about three paragraphs, presenting points to support your argument.
- You will have worked out your ***ideas*** in the planning stage, when ***organizing*** your ideas. Now it is simply a matter of ***presenting one main point in each paragraph.***
- The body of a basic essay may have as many body paragraphs as it is necessary to prove the author's argument of the thesis statement.
- It is vital to keep in mind that each paragraph is supposed to have one main argument to analyze and has to reveal it in one solid thought in a sentence called the **topic sentence.**
- Therefore the number of the body paragraphs equals the amount of topic sentences.
- Each body paragraph must be connected to following one with a logical link.

3. concluding paragraph

- The conclusion always deals with summing up the essays arguments revealed in the topic sentences and the therefore present substantial evidence to prove the thesis statement.
- It is also important to mention the importance of the general conclusion of the essay.
- It is usually written in one solid paragraph.

Sample Essay

The Benefits of Television

We hear a lot about the negative effects of television on the viewer. Obviously, television can be harmful if it is watched constantly to the exclusion of other activities. It would be just as harmful to listen to CDs all the time or to eat constantly. However, when television is watched in moderation, it is extremely valuable, as it provides relaxation, entertainment and education.

First of all, watching television has a value of sheer relaxation. Watching television can be soothing and restful after an eight-hour day pressure, challenges, or concentration. After working hard all day, people look forward to a new episode of a favorite show or yet another showing of Casablanca or sleeplessness in Seattle. This period of relaxation leaves viewers refreshed and ready to take on the world again. Watching TV also seems to reduce stress in some people. This benefit of television is just beginning to be recognized. One doctor, for example, advises his patients with high blood pressure to relax in the evening with a few hours of television.

In addition to being relaxing, television is entertaining. Along with the standard comedies, dramas and game shows that provide enjoyment to viewers, television offers a variety of movies and sports events. Moreover, in many areas, viewers can pay a monthly fee and receive special cable programming. With this service, viewers can watch first-run movies, rock and classical music concerts, and specialized sports events, like international soccer and Grand Prix racing. Viewers can also buy or rent movies to show on their TV sets through DVD players or VCDs. Still another growing area of TV entertainment is video games. Cartridges are available for everything from electronic baseball to Mortal Kombat, allowing the owner to have a video game arcade in the living room.

Most important, television is educational. Preschoolers learn colors, numbers and letters from public television programmes, like Sesame Street, that use animation and puppets to make learning fun. Science shows for older children, like fun with nature, go on location to analyze everything from volcanoes to rocket launches. Adults, too, can get an education from courses given on TV. Also, TV widens our knowledge by covering important events and current news. Viewers can see and hear presidents' speeches, state funerals, natural disasters and election results as they are happening. Finally, with a phone line and special terminal television allows any member of the family to access and learn from all the information resources on the internet.

Perhaps because a television is such a powerful force, we like to criticize it and search for its flows. However, the benefits of TV should not be ignored. We can use television to relax, to have fun and to make ourselves smarter. This electronic wonder, then, is a servant, not a master.

Exercises

Below are paragraphs which are taken from different essays. Decide which ones are taken from which structure of an essay (*introduction, body*, or *conclusion*).

1. Catalog shopping at home, then, has several advantages. Such shopping is convenient, saves you money and saves you time. It is not surprising that growing numbers of devoted catalog shoppers are welcoming those full-color mail brochures that offer everything from turnip speeds to televisions.

2. What is love? How do we know that we are really in love? When we meet that special person, how can we tell that our feelings are genuine and not merely infatuation? And, if they are genuine, will these feelings last? Love, as we all know, is difficult to define. But most people agree that true and lasting love involves far more than mere physical attraction. Love involves mutual respect, the desire to give than take, and the feeling of being wholly at ease.

3. To begin with, I just don't enjoy the general hassle of the evening. Since small local movie theatres are a thing of the past, I have to drive for fifteen minutes to get to the nearest multiplex. The parking lot is shared with several restaurants and supermarket, so it is always jammed. I have to drive around at snail's pace until I spot another driver backing out. Then it is time to stand in an endless line, with the constant threat that tickets for the show I want will sell out.

Identify the types of the following essays.

Essay 1

My mother, who is seventy years old, recently sent me a photograph of herself that I had never seen before. While cleaning out the attic of her Florida home, she came across a studio portrait she had had taken about a year before she married my father. This picture of my mother, as a twenty- year-old girl and the story behind it, has fascinated me from the moment I began to consider it.

The young woman in the picture has a face that resembles my own in many ways. Her face is a bit more oval than mine, but the softly waving brown hair around it is identical. The small, straight nose is the same model I was born with. My mother's mouth is closed, yet there is just the slightest hint of a small on her full lips. I know that if she had smiled, she would have shown the same wide grin and down-curving "smile lines" that appear in my own snapshots. The most haunting feature in the photo, however, is my mother's eyes. They are an exact duplicate of my own large, dark-brown ones. Her brows are plucked into thin lines, which are like two pencil strokes added to highlight those fine, luminous eyes.

I have also carefully studied the clothing and jewelry in the photograph. Although the photo was taken fifty years ago, my mother is wearing a blouse and skirt that could easily be worn today. The blouse is made of heavy eggshell-colored satin and reflects the light in its folds and hollows. It has a turned-down cowl collar and smocking on the shoulders and below the collar. The smocking (tiny rows of gathered material) looks hand-done. The skirt, which covers my mother's calves, is straight and made of light wool or flannel. My mother is wearing silver drop earrings. They are about two inches long and roughly shield-shaped. On her left wrist is a matching bracelet. My mother can't find this bracelet now, despite the fact

that we spent hours searching through the attic for it. On the third finger of her left hand is a ring with a large, square-cut stone.

The story behind the picture is as interesting to me as the young woman it captures. Mom, who was earning twenty-five dollars a week as a file clerk, decided to give her boyfriend (my father) a picture of herself. She spent almost two weeks' salary on the skirt and blouse, which she bought at a fancy department store downtown. She borrowed the earrings and bracelet from her older sister, my Aunt Dorothy. The ring she wore was a present from another young man she was dating at the time. Mom spent another chunk of her salary to pay the portrait photographer for the hand-tinted print in old-fashioned tones of brown and tan. Just before giving the picture to my father, she scrawled at the lower left, "Sincerely, Beatrice."

When I study this picture, I react in many ways. I think about the trouble that Mom went to in order to impress the young man who was to be my father. I laugh when I look at the ring, which was probably worn to make my father jealous. I smile at the serious, formal inscription my mother used at this stage of the budding relationship. Sometimes, I am filled with a mixture of pleasure and sadness when I look at this frozen long-ago moment. It is a moment of beauty, of love, and - a way – of my own past.

Essay 2

One day Ann was out walking, just for exercise. Near the entrance to a park, she saw a small crowd of people standing in a circle. They were looking at something. She crossed the street to get a better look.

In the middle of the circle, or ring, of people there was an old woman and a monkey. That's what everybody was looking at. On the ground near the monkey was a hat. It was upside down. The woman wanted the monkey to do a trick but the monkey did nothing. It just sat there on the ground. Perhaps this monkey was very stupid. Or maybe it just did not want to do any tricks. The old woman shouted at the monkey more and more loudly. Suddenly, the monkey stood on its back legs, screamed and fell over.

The woman went near it. She bent over the monkey. It did not move. She called its name. It still did not move. She touched it tenderly, whispering its name one more time. The old woman got down on her knees. She put her ear against the monkey's chest and listened. Then she whispered, 'He's dead!' and began to cry. From time to time she said again, 'Dead. Dead. My only friend. What will I do now? How will I live without my monkey?' A young man stepped towards the hat, took a five-pound note out of a pocket and dropped it in the hat. He turned to the crowd and said, 'We have to help her. Can't you see, her life is ruined?' He then walked away.

Other people began to move towards the hat, taking notes and coins out of their pockets and handbags and dropping them in. Ann did the same. Several months later, Ann was in a different city, on business. One lunch time, she decided to go for a walk. It was a beautiful spring day and she could see on her map that there was a park nearby. She decided to buy a sandwich and eat it on a bench in the park. About ten minutes later, she got to the park entrance. Near it was a crowd of people looking at something. Ann joined them. In the middle was an old woman and a monkey. Near them was an upside down hat.

It was the same woman and the same monkey. Again the monkey screamed and fell over. Again the woman cried. Again a young man stepped forward and put money in the hat and spoke to the crowd. It was the same hat and the same young man.